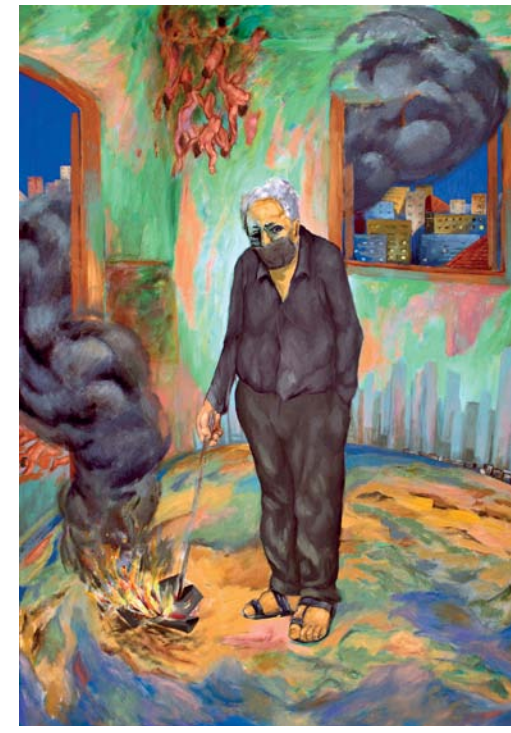
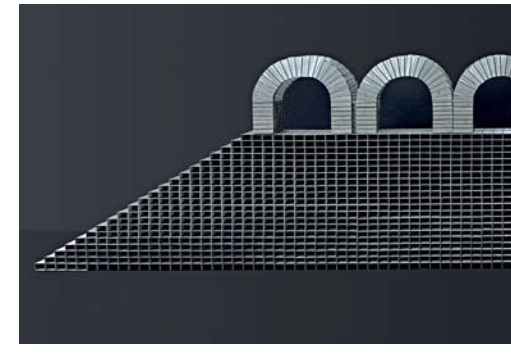






FRAMING DEVICES
(Clockwise from top left): 'Home' by Sudipta Das, 'Smoke' by Sudhir Patwardhan, 'A Story Unfolds' by Pooja Iranna

After an hour in the brightly-lit exhibition area of the India Art Fair last Saturday, I escaped to the comfortingly dim auditorium and found a perch at the very back, near the photographers. An elegant older woman in white was speaking to a chatty man who seemed to know her well. It was Kiran Nadar, I soon realised: philanthropist and founder of the Kiran Nadar Museum of Art. The interviewer was Dinesh Vazirani of the Mumbai-based auction house SaffronArt, whose first art auction of 2022 had generated record sales of Rs 104.1 crore in April.

On stage, Vazirani began a rapid-fire round. "Your favourite painting in the world?" he asked, adding: "Shall I tell you?" Nadar indulged him. It was Gustav Klimt's 'Woman in Gold'. Stolen by the Nazis in the 1940s and won back by the Jewish Bauer family only in 2006, Nadar told the audience that Adele Bloch-Bauer's portrait always makes her cry. They must make time to visit the Frick Collection to see it, she added, "when next in New York".

It so happens that 'Woman in Gold' hangs not at the Frick, but at another of New York's smaller art museums, the Neue Galerie. But that doesn't change Nadar's feeling for the painting, which she successfully transmitted to her listeners—even if they didn't often go to New York.

The moment encapsulated one of the most powerful things about the India Art Fair (IAF): its careful mix of insider- and outsider-ness. The walls between insiders and outsiders are fiercely guarded in most domains, but seem particularly high around visual art. Contemporary abstract art alienates many. An untrained eye is an aesthetic barrier. The lack of knowledge of art history is an intellectual and social barrier. Finally, there's the economic barrier: art is priced far beyond most budgets, even upper-middle-class ones. The IAF seems more conscious of these barriers than most art institutions in post-Independence India have been. And as a commercial enterprise, it has a stake in wanting more outsiders to visit, to feel like insiders and, ideally, buy.

Founded by the young entrepreneur Neha Kirpal in 2008 with 34 galleries showing in Pragati Maidan, the 2022 edition had 77 exhibitors spread across 15,000 square metres in Okhla's NSIC Grounds. Covid had some dampening effects: in 2020, there were 81 participants, 14 of them international. In 2022, there were only four international galleries, and few non-Indian visitors. But as IAF's Digital and Communications head Gautami Reddy told me, the absence of international buyers pushed IAF to increase outreach within India. In the months preceding the fair, the IAF team, headed by Jaya Asokan, looked beyond the hubs of Delhi and Mumbai, expanding their buyer demographic by cultivating corporate and entrepreneurial networks, including forums of architects and designers.

The effort seems to have paid off. "We're seeing a passion for collecting from Hyderabad, Bengaluru, Chennai, Indore, Chandigarh, even Kolkata, where building a buyer base has been hard for IAF," said Reddy. "Other new buyers are visiting under the guiding eye of an architect or interior designer,